The Brave Little Toaster

By Thomas M. Disch

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

(Division of characters and narration duties should be equally divided between the actors – However, each actor should maintain character consistency throughout: If you start out as the TOASTER, always be the TOASTER)

NARRATOR 1: They lived in a cottage, deep in a forest unreachable by civilization. They were very devoted to their master -- that was just their nature as appliances.

NARRATOR 2: There was an old vacuum, the leader (I'm a Hoover).

NARRATOR 1: The off white plastic alarm clock radio (AM only),

NARRATOR 2: A cheerful yellow electric blanket (wanna cuddle?)

NARRATOR 1: And a neurotic tensor lamp ("I'm the outsider I have no friends)

NARRATOR 2: Finally, there was the toaster, a bright little Sunbeam (cute little "hi").

NARRATOR 1: But living so long in the woods had changed them in some nice, indefinable way that made the thought of any alternate lifestyle unthinkable . . .

NARRATOR 2: Or so they thought!

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INTRODUCTION

Actor 1: *You would think that in being a talking appliance you would not have anything to worry about.*
Actor 2: *Unfortunately for these five friends that is not the case.*
Actor 1: *They have been left to fend for themselves in the wilderness by their now "grown up" master.*
Actor 2: *As they set out into the world to try and find him they find adventure, ghosts, and what kind of wiring they are truly made of.*
TOGETHER: *The Brave Little Toaster by Thomas M. Disch*

TOASTER: We can't go on like this; it isn't natural for appliances to live all by themselves. We need people to take care of; we need people to take care of us. Soon one by one we will all ware out and no one will fix us because no one will know what has happened to us. There's nothing else to do but to find the master.

VACUUM: The toaster's right, something must be done. Do you have any suggestions?

TOASTER: Don't you remember just last week there was a story that the radio was telling us about a dear little fox terrier who had been accidentally left behind at a cottage just like us. And found his master thousands of miles away in a city somewhere in Canada.

BLANKET: That's it that's how we'll find our way! But dogs have legs.

TOASTER: The vacuum shall be our legs!

VACUUM: I beg your pardon?

TOASTER: I meant to say our wheels.

LAMP: And build a kind of carriage!

RADIO: And ride all the way there!

TOASTER: The question is…will you be able to? (Vacuum rumbles)

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NARRATOR 1: One Friday, the Hoover as usual, had been grumbling about the old metal wheelie chair that stood in front of the Master's desk. The toaster had an idea.

NARRATOR 2: They tied the Hoover's cord to the base of the chair and hopped on. They set out to find their master as the Hoover pulled them along. Soon the dear little summer cottage was lost from sight behind the leaves and branches of the forest trees.

NARRATOR 1: As the day worn on the Hoover was obliged to stop more and more frequently.

VACUUM: Can you believe how filthy the forest is?

BLANKET: On the contrary, it's thoroughly agreeable. The air's so fresh, and just the feel the breeze! I feel renewed, as if I'd just come out of my box. Oh why, why, why don't they ever take electric blankets on picnics? It isn't fair!

RADIO: Enjoy it while it lasts, kiddo. According to the latest weather and traffic roundup, we're in for rain.

LAMP: Won't the trees act like a roof? They keep the sunlight out well enough.

NARRATOR 1: None of them knew the answer to the lamps question, but as it happens, trees do not work like a roof. And it started to rain.

NARRATOR 2: The electric blanket spread out and sheltered the other four appliances. Later the toaster woke from a terrible nightmare. Thunder was thundering and lightning was streaking the sky. With Dismay the toaster realized that the electric blanket had disappeared.

LAMP: Where's the blanket?

RADIO: Blown away, blown off to the far end of the forest.

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LAMP: I should have known I should have known, we should have never left home.

VACUUM: It's not our fault.

NARRATOR 1: In a flash of lightning they saw the blanket tangled in a tree.

TOASTER: BLANKEEEEEEEEEE….t.

RADIO: You can come down now!

BLANKET: I can't I'm stuck.

VACUUM: Don't be a wet blanket

BLANKET: I can't get down, There's a great rip right through the center of me. I hurt.

SQUIRREL: "What the deuce is all the racket about."

NARRATOR 2: Spoke a squirrel stepping forward from his nest high in the trunk of the oak. The appliances apologized and with the help of the squirrel they got blanket down (Squirrel and blanket interaction).

TOASTER: How shall we ever be able to repay you?

SQUIRREL: Well, I can't remember whether or not you said you were nuts, I mean if you had any nuts.

VACUUM: Believe me, if we did you would have them all. But you can see for yourself that my bag contains nothing but dust (empty hoover)

NARRATOR 1: And they continued on their way. And what a long and wary way it was! (pantomime section)

NARRATOR 2: Toward evening…

RADIO: I'm receiving interference from a source quite nearby. Just on the other side of that river.

LAMP: Hurrah! (appliance dance) –hits boat—AHHHH! I've found a boat!

VACUUM: You don't intend for us to use the boat, do you?

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TOASTER: Of course! This will take us directly across the river.

BLANKET: It doesn't belong to us. If we were to take it, we'd be no better than…than pirates!

RADIO: Pirates! Us? Who ever heard of an appliance that was a pirate?

TOASTER: We wouldn't keep it. We'd just borrow it.

NARRATOR 1: With courage renewed and determination strengthened they set out. BUT! Something made it stop. The owner of the boat had returned.

BOAT OWNER: Why what's this? It seems we have some visitors!

NARRATOR 1: He said so much more than this, but in a manner so rough and ill mannered that it is better not to repeat his words verbatim. The sum of it was- the owner of the boat believed the owner of the appliances had been about to steal his boat, and so he intended by way of retaliation to steal the appliances, and brought them to the city dump!!!!

BOAT OWNER: It's junk…all of it.

RADIO: It's true.

BLANKET: That's all I am now—junk! Look at me!

LAMP: My bulb! My poor, poor bulb!

VACUUM: This is where I belong…

TOASTER: Pull yourselves together, all of you! There's nothing wrong with us! Now here is my plan. We'll frighten him, and that will make him run away.

LAMP: But what if the gate is locked? It is now!

TOASTER: No, because he will have to unlock it to get out himself, and he'll be too frightened to remember to lock it behind him.

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RADIO: It's a very good plan, but what I don't understand is—how we are going to frighten him?

TOASTER: Well, what are people afraid of the most?

VACUUM: Getting run over by a steamroller

TOASTER: No, scarier than that.

BLANKET: Moths

TOASTER: No, they are afraid of ghosts.

BLANKET: What are ghosts?

TOASTER: Ghosts are people who are dead, only they're also sort of alive.

VACUUM: Don't be silly, either they are dead or they aren't.

BLANKET: Yes, it's as simple as on and off. If you are turned on you can't be turned off.

TOASTER: The point is this—people are afraid of ghosts. And so we're going to pretend to be one.

VACUUM: How?

TOASTER: Let me show you.

NARRATOR 2: After an hour's practice of pretending to be a ghost, they decided they were ready. The blanket draped over the vacuum in a roughly ghostlike shape with a kind of hood at the top through which the toaster was able to peer out, adjusted its folds one last time.

TOASTER: Ready?

VACUUM: Ready.

BLANKET: Ready.

TOASTER: Then let's start haunting.

TOASTER: Whoo!

BOAT OWNER: Who's there?

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TOASTER: Whoo—oo!

BOAT OWNER: Whoever you are, you'd better go away.

TOASTER: Whoo—oo—oo!

BOAT OWNER: If you won't say who you are, I'm going to come out there and find out!

TOASTER: WHOOOOOOOO!

BOAT OWNER: I'm warning you! (Toaster comes around, scares owner "AHHHHH!!!" run around in circle)

NARRATOR 1: They then drove off as fast as their wheels would revolve. As luck would have it, they didn't have far to go: where the master lived on Newton Avenue was only a mile or so from the dump. They reached his apartment building early in the morning

TOASTER: You see, in the end everything really does work out for the best.

NARRATOR 1: Alas their tribulations were not yet at an end, and not everything…would work out for the best. When they reached the apartment they were greeted by the "new" appliances who informed the five friends that the master means to sell the cottage in the woods and auction them off.

TOASTER: Come all of you come. We are not wanted here. We'll return…to…

BLANKET: The Dump…

RADIO: No…there's another way.

NARRATOR 2: The next afternoon at five o'clock the radio's alarm went off, and everyone became very silent.

BLANKET: What is it?

RADIO: Hush. It's time for the swap shop. It's a program on listener radio station KHOP! That is going to find a new home for us! I told you not to worry, didn't I? I told you I'd think of something?

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(mumbo jumbo radio announcer)

RADIO: Didn't he make us sound super! Come over here by the telephone.

NARRATOR 1: All of the appliances gathered about the telephone and waited for it to ring. (The phone rings).

VACUUM: Now whatever you do don't say yes to the first person who happens to call. Find out something about him first.

RADIO: Right.

TOASTER: And remember to be nice.

RADIO: Hello?

MISTRESS: Is this the person with five appliances?

RADIO: It is! Oh my goodness yes indeed it is!

NARRATOR 1: And so the appliances went to live with their new mistress, for as it happened it was a woman who'd phoned them first and not a man. The appliances were very happy.

NARRATOR 2: It felt so good to be useful again!

NARRATOR 1: And so the five appliances lived and worked happy and fulfilled, serving their dear mistress and enjoying each other's companionship, to the end of their days.

TOASTER: You see, in the end…everything really does work out for the best.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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